Cowboys

By Susan Steinberg

SPEAKER: There are some who say I did not kill my father. Not technically they mean.

INTRODUCTION

The grief that comes with losing a parent, spouse or sibling after a long illness can be devastating. But there is an additional burden for family members involved in making end-of-life care decisions on behalf of their loved ones. Surrogate decision-makers can be haunted by lingering doubts about whether they made the right choices for family members or may feel guilty about those decisions. They often feel anxious and depressed, and are at significant risk for posttraumatic stress disorder. And the distress is slow to fade. Cowboys by Susan Steinberg

SPEAKER: When the doctor called at four a.m., waked me from a dream I can almost remember, something about chasing dogs in a field, something about a fence, he introduced himself as the doctor. He said, I am doctor such-and-such, in this uptight voice, this deadpan voice. And I laughed and said, You're who. I said, Who is this.

My brother was also on the line. My brother was in Boston. The doctor was in Baltimore. And I was in a place called Warrensburg, Missouri. I was in Warrensburg, Missouri, for a job I was trying to quit. When I mention Warrensburg, Missouri, people say, Where is that. I tell them there are cowboys there. I tell them there are tornadoes that can blow your house across the state. There are brown recluse spiders, I tell them, in every corner of every room. And there I was, trying my best to sleep right through it, a doctor telling me, at four a.m., please, to please be serious.

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I was not always serious, and somehow the doctor already knew this, knew perhaps because I laughed when he said he was the doctor. Or perhaps he knew because my brother told him I would not be serious. Or perhaps he knew because when he told me to kill my father, I laughed again. He did not, of course, use the word *kill*. He had another word, a series of words, a more technical way of wording. The doctor sounded exhausted . . . [He] had been up all night. Trying to save your father, he said. To no avail, he said, and I wondered at the word *avail*, wondered if the doctor got to be a doctor because of whatever it was he had that made him use that word.

The doctor said my father had flatlined several times. I knew the word *flatlined* from my ex, who had flatlined three times when we were together. He had flatlined, my ex, because he was an addict, and being an addict, as it turns out, will make you flatline. After the first time, my mother, a nurse, said, He'll never be the same. But he was the same, as it turned out, because he flatlined again. After the third time, we broke up. I'd like to say we broke up because I'd had enough, but really he broke up with me for another woman, a thinner woman, a paler woman, the veins too vivid through her face, and she eventually flatlined too, and she eventually died from this, but he did not. He became a firefighter. I moved to Warrensburg, Missouri. The whole world just went on.

The doctor said my father would be a vegetable, and upon hearing this word, I imagined a plate. I imagined vegetables on this plate. One does not want to imagine this. One wants to imagine one's father running

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through a field, arms spread, something dynamic like that. Something totally made up like that.

The doctor said my name. He said, Please. My brother said my name. I had a decision to make. I had a serious decision to make, because I was the older kid. Though, as stated, I was not the more serious of the two. And my serious brother, was waiting for me to do the right thing.

This was years ago, and I'm telling you this because the story came to me today for no real reason, just because I happened to see a guy digging through the trash, and I was like, You again. I was like, Get out of there. And I'm telling you this, because some have been wondering why I am the way I am. Which is to say a mess. Which is to say a lot of things.

I could not at first kill my father. I at first said no. I said, Not as long as he's still breathing. But he isn't breathing, said the doctor. Not technically, he said. The doctor sounded fed up. But not fed up with the limitations of science. And not with the limitations of the human body.

The doctor said, A machine is making him breathe. He did not use the word *machine.* I said I would have to call my mother to get her advice, and my brother said, Don't be a dumbass, and the doctor sighed in that way that the *guys* I have dated since this night sigh when they don't get what they want. Like the restaurant is out of chicken wings. Like the beer is flat. Like I'm trying to convince them I'm a terrible person. The sigh applies pressure to the woman. Then the woman is supposed to give them what they want. Which is to say the woman is then supposed to perform.

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Which is to say the woman is then supposed to know the subtle difference between being a woman and performing one.

I said, I'm calling our mother. My mother was in Miami. I disconnected, pressed some buttons, and there was my mother. Then I reconnected, and there we all were. I said, They want me to kill Dad.

My mother had left my father thirty years before. There is no reason to go into the details. I was not calling my mother because she loved my father. I was not even calling her because she was my mother. I was calling her because she was a nurse. I hoped that because she was a nurse she would tell me the right thing to do. I'm not talking morally. I'm talking medically. She knew about this.

My mother said, What. My brother said, Tell her. The doctor said, He flatlined. My mother said, You have to kill him. She did not, of course, use these words. I don't know why I'm being so melodramatic. She used technical terms. She said, Take him off the respirator. She said, It's the right thing to do. She said, Trust me. She said, I need to go, though. She said, I need to get to work. She said, I'm sorry. And because I more often than not do the wrong thing, I said fine.

A few days later, because I was older, because the decision was mine, I would donate my father's body to science. I would do this over the phone, and the conversation would be recorded. A woman would ask me questions I had not before this heard. Do you wish to donate the lungs. Do you wish to donate the heart. There were other organs one doesn't

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think of. There were other things besides organs. The tissue was to go to the tissue bank. The eyes were to go to the eye bank. There were other things I can't remember.

But it was the thought of the eyes removed from the head, the thought of the eyes going their own way, that made me cry. I don't know why this was. I was not suddenly a believer of the soul. I was not suddenly a believer of anything. It was just thinking about it.

And as I cried, the woman said, It's okay, said, Let it out, and I stopped crying and sat there, silent, and the recording went on, just recorded my breathing, the woman's breathing, the sound of static in the phone, and minutes passed. And I thought for some reason of a night years before, me, my father, and my brother in some fast-food place.

My brother was visiting home from college, and he was sticking his French fries into his milk shake, and I said, Sick, and he said, Try it, and I stuck a French fry into the milk shake, and it was amazing. My father was poor then, always poorer the next day, living in some hole, like a hostel, like a hospital, like a halfway house, and my brother said he would take him to dinner. Anywhere you want, he said. My father wanted to go to the fast-food place. He met us there. He was filthy. His shirt was missing buttons. He ordered two cheeseburgers. He ordered onion rings. He ordered an orange soda. He ate too fast. And, watching us stick French fries into the milk shake, he said, You're both sick. But then he tried it too, and then he laughed, and then we ordered more French fries and another milk shake, and what I'm trying to say is, you should try it.

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What I'm trying to say is. What I'm trying to say is. . . .

I did not donate the eyes to the eye bank. At some point I said, I can't. The parts that didn't go to science were burned. And, no, I did not want the ashes. I told the woman to send the ashes to my brother. Because my brother was a better person than I was.

There are no more details to tell. There is no reason to go into the why of my father. Or the why of madness, which I cannot answer. Or the why of addiction, which I also cannot answer. Or the why of poor, which I also cannot answer. Suffice it to say it's always about a loss of something. Then a loss of some things. Then a loss of all things. Then he was already dead, some might say. What do you mean, I might say back. If he had already lost everything, some might say, then he was already dead. Yes, I might say. Then you didn't kill him, some might say as they move toward me. That's not the point . . . Then what is . . .

There were late nights he would call from a pay phone, a friend's house, a hospital, and because it was late, and because I was not poor, and because I was not ferociously mad, but, rather, mad mad, a machine answered my phone and lied that I wasn't there eating in bed, watching TV, lied that I would return the call. The machine would then say, Hello, stranger. The machine would then say, It's your father, stranger. There were voices in the background. There was traffic in the background. I'm okay, stranger, the machine would then say. There was screaming in the background. There was me in my bedroom. Pick up the phone, the machine would say loudly. I know you're there, the machine would say louder.

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There was me turning the TV all the way up. There was every poor soul looking downward. There was me not believing in the soul. Call it what you will, but there I was, just some poor soul. Same as you.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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